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Yutong (Max) Zhu

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Education

University of Chicago — Chicago, IL
Ph.D., Sociology — *Expected 2031*

University of Chicago — Chicago, IL
M.A., Computational Social Science — *Jun 2025*

Carnegie Mellon University — Pittsburgh, PA
B.S. (University Honors), Computer Science;
Additional Major in History — *May 2022*

Peer-Reviewed Articles

≡ *indicates equal contribution and shared first authorship.*

[3] Zehan Li, **Yutong Zhu**, Siyang Wu, Honglin Bao, James A. Evans. "Narrative Flattening: How Post-Training Compresses Thematic, Affective, and Stylistic Variation in LLM Fiction." Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing (EMNLP) 2026 (**Oral**). [Preprint].

[2] Peiqi Sui≡, **Yutong Zhu**≡, Tianyi Cheng, Peter West, Richard Jean So, Hoyt Long, Ari Holtzman. "Spoiler Alert: Narrative Forecasting as a Metric for Tension in LLM Storytelling." Conference on Language Modeling (COLM) 2026. [Preprint].

[1] **Zhu, Yutong**. "Explaining Gendered Language Through Embedding Approximation: How 'Stupid' Became a Man's Word." *Social Forces*, 2026, article soag103 (Advance Access). [DOI]

Papers Under Review

[1] Rochelle Terman, Shilin Jia, **Yutong Zhu**, and James Evans. "The Nations in Our Minds: Historical Representations of Countries in Google Books." In submission.

Works in Progress

[1] **Zhu, Yutong**, Tianyi Zhang, Junsol Kim, Aaron Schein, and James Evans. "Language models encode the structure of a belief system and flatten it at their output." *Manuscript in preparation.*

Presentations

"How 'Stupid' Became a Man's Word," American Sociological Association (ASA) Annual Meeting — 2025

"The Nations in Our Minds," International Studies Association (ISA) Annual Convention — 2025

"Between Min and Zu," Midwest Conference on Asian Affairs (MCAA) — 2024

Honors & Awards

University Scholar Full-Tuition Scholarship, University of Chicago, 2023–2025

Ludwig Schaefer Award for Outstanding Achievement in History, Carnegie Mellon University, 2022

Dietrich College Senior Honors Fellowship, Carnegie Mellon University, 2021

Teaching Experience

University of Chicago

- Mathematics for Social Science (Fall 2026), Dr. Mark Hansen
- Large-Scale Computing for the Social Sciences (Spring 2025), Dr. Jon Clindaniel, Dr. Fabricio Vasselai
- Perspectives on Computational Modeling (Winter 2025), Dr. Zhao Wang

Professional Experience

Journal of Asian Studies — Remote
Editorial Assistant (Part-Time) — *Mar 2023 – Jun 2025*

Stellar Cyber — San Jose, CA
Data Engineer — *Jun 2022 – Feb 2023*

Skills

Methods: Data Management, Quantitative & Qualitative Research, Academic Writing, Data Analysis & Pipeline, Machine Learning, NLP

Technical: Python, C, Java, SPARQL, SQL, Kubernetes, Git; Adobe Photoshop, Illustrator, InDesign

Languages: Mandarin (native), French (intermediate), Uzbek (elementary)

References

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Max Palevsky Professor of Sociology & Data Science
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John Levi Martin
Florence Borchert Bartling Professor, Sociology
University of Chicago
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Bernard Koch
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